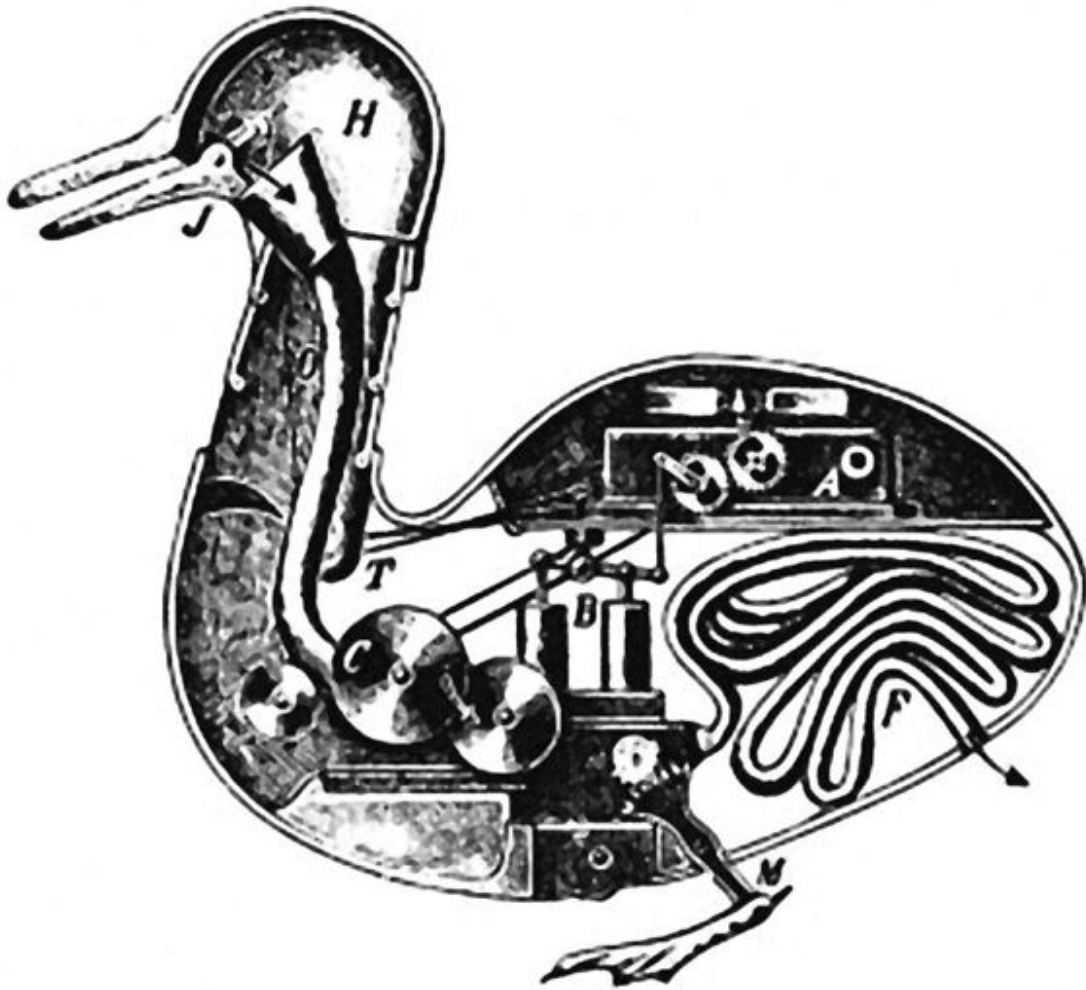


Animals as automata



Vaucanson's 'digesting duck' was a mechanical automaton that could walk, flap its wings, eat, drink and defecate.

Advances in science and engineering during the 17th and 18th centuries fostered a mechanistic view of the physical world. Objects and their actions were explained in the same terms as machines, subject to the laws of physics. The difference between the physical and the mental in Descartes's dualism was stark, putting human thought and consciousness outside the physical realm. This was based on the idea that humans are capable of rational thought – but what of animals?

It was generally believed that animals were incapable of reasoning, so would not have minds to exist as immaterial mental substance in the same way as human minds. In the Cartesian view, animals are simply a part of the physical world, subject to physical laws, and behave in the same way as machines: it is a mistake to interpret their actions as evidence of consciousness or mental activity. This idea was reinforced at the time by ingenious automata that exhibited similar behaviour to animals, but patently had no mind.